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So, yes, thank you so much for being here. I really appreciate you participating for me. And today I wanted to talk a bit about voice recordings and homesickness. And how are you feeling today?

I am a bit tired and jet lagged. I landed yesterday from the US.

Okay. You landed from the US. Yeah. So, were you there for a long time?

Almost a month.

Almost a month. Okay. Okay. Could you tell me where you're originally from? Just a check.

Yes. I'm originally from Bulgaria. I was born in Varna, in Bulgaria.

Yes. Okay. So, you grew up there. And where do you currently live?

I currently live in St. Gallen in Switzerland.

Okay. And what do you consider to be home?

That's a hard question. I don't consider... I don't think I consider a physical place home. Or if I did, there would be many. It would not be one place. Yes. I usually find home with people that know me very well, family and friends that I have made along the way. And every time I visit them or they visit me, I feel home.

Okay. Yeah. Great. And so, do you remember a time in your life when you felt the most homesick? Or at least a period where you felt a lot of homesickness? And so, when was this? Where were you? What did you miss?

Yeah. Okay. I think I do remember. Like, there are definitely more times, but I think that was the most recent, maybe. Or... I think... Or like, two instances of recent ones. Once. And it's... I think the most... I feel the most homesick when I just have moved to a new place. Yeah. Because things are hard. There are a lot of logistics to be figured out. And I feel, like, lonely that I don't have my people around to help. And to rely on when... In that difficult time that, for example, I don't know. Like, when I moved here in St. Gallen, I had absolutely nothing in the apartment. There were even no lights. No furniture. Nothing. And I knew nobody. So, that was like... I really felt homesick because I was missing support of friends and family. And I was... Yeah. I think mostly from that perspective. And the previous time that this happened was

when I moved to Netherlands. Yeah. And it was the same situation, basically. But just a different place. And to one year earlier. So... Yeah.

Yeah. So, and then you mostly missed just the support of having people that you know around you?

Yeah.

Yeah. Okay. So, I want to go into how personal or generic a voice recording would feel like to you. And what I mean with personal is that it... Well, obviously, it first feels personally for you. So, it doesn't necessarily mean that the audio needs to originate from someone that's close to you. But it can also just have a personal connection linguistically, culturally, historically. And it just needs to feel close to you. And generic, on the other hand, is every recording that's not having that personal connection for you.

Okay. Is there a scale or what...

So, I'm going to go into just an open question first. And that's basically for just imagining voice recordings existing in general or any type of audio that has a voice. So, it could be documentaries as well, whatever you can imagine. Which types of voice recordings do you think would feel more personal to you and why?

Okay. Alright. Yes. So, let me see.

That was an open question. So, you can just answer it however you want.

Okay. So... Yes. Like, I thought that you were going to play some recordings. How...

Okay, okay. I get... Sorry.

No problem. No problem. How personal a voice recording is versus how generic. I think voice recording is... Can hold a lot of personal value. Even if it's not a person close to me. Music can touch me like... By lyrics or like whatever. It's like... The music holds as an emotion. As well as voices. Like, I... The first thing I think about is podcasts. There's like one really good one that's called Modern Love. From the New York Times. And they record people telling stories that are deeply personal to them. And they're not deeply personal to me. But I always feel... How do you say? Like... Influenced by... By them. So... I think they could be very... Right. Not necessarily every voice recording can be personal. But some can be. Yes.

And what do you think are characteristics that would make it then personal for you?

I think if it holds... Yeah. Something that I resonate with. Either in a story format or a music. I think it's mostly also the emotion in the voice might carry a significance. And... And... I think the vulnerability in how vulnerable whatever whoever did the recording is. Yeah.

Yeah. Okay. And so... What do you think would make a recording more generic for you?

If it's just basic information. Like, I don't know, the weather. Or if it's... I don't know. Yeah. Like... I guess that's... That's maybe a bit more difficult question than personal.

All right. So... I have another questionnaire that I'm actually going to share with you in the chat. I'm just going to get it here.

Yes.

And then what I want you to do is just open this and keep it open during the whole interview. It has a couple of items.

Wait. I need to enter.

Yes. So the first thing is just your personal information. The email address or the phone number. And then I'm going to let you hear five different voice recordings. And you can rate them. First of all, you can rate them based on how generic or personal they feel. So the first statement you see is someone from a different country talking in a different language you're not very familiar with about the weather. I'm going to let you hear a voice recording that corresponds to that. You can give the rating. And then when you're done, you can say, go on to the next recording. And the next statement is for the next recording.

Okay. There is always one statement per recording.

Yes. Exactly. And then after five recordings, we can just go back to the questionnaire, back to the interview. And we do that two more times.

Okay.

All right. So you just let me know if you're ready.

Um. Okay.

[Voice recording audio: recording 1]

Ready?

Okay

[Voice recording audio: recording 2]

[Voice recording audio: recording 5]

[Voice recording audio: recording 12]

All right, ready for the last one?

Mm-hmm.

[Voice recording audio: recording 19]

All right. So did you fill in those five?

Yeah, I'm thinking...

No hurry.

I guess... Yeah, okay. I'll give you feedback later. But... Yes. I... Yeah, I filled them out. Should I click the arrow?

Yeah, so you can go to the next one and then we'll... You can just leave the questionnaire open, but I'm gonna go back to the interview now.

Okay.

All right. So, based on those five recordings, what do you think are characteristics or maybe anything about the voice recordings that made it more personal or more generic? And why?

Mm-hmm. Mm-hmm. Um... So, yeah, definitely I don't know French, so I was not understanding what they were talking about. I could distinguish the different emotion in the voices of the... I guess the person who was talking in the historical speech versus the one in the weather forecast.

Yeah.

There was definitely a difference there. But then I guess when it was also the language that I understand, I was focusing more on who is talking or like what they're saying. Uh, and, uh, actually for me they're all the same. Yeah. Right now. Um... And they are not, like they are somewhat personal, I act like. But, uh, and that is because, um... I'm not a fan, for example, of the politician who was talking in the second audio recording and the lady in the third, the recording sounded very generic. Yeah. Uh, so yeah.

Yeah, so would you say it's mostly the tone of voice and then the topic they're talking about, but also for the fourth one specifically just the political view also has an influence?

Yeah, yeah.

Okay. So next up I'm gonna go into meaningfulness of recordings. And this is a little bit different than, uh, for example, personal.

Mm-hmm.

So I mean if it feels in any way just important or relevant to you, and if it actually resonates to you and to what extent it means something to you.

Mm-hmm.

So it can be emotionally, but it can also be important without emotions, just basically purely based off topic. Um, and a recording could of course be very personal and not meaningful, but it could be not personal and very meaningful.

Mm-hmm. Mm-hmm. Okay.

All right. So if you would think about voice recordings in general again, what do you think could make a voice recording meaningful to you?

Okay, so in terms of, it has meaning, but it could be a negative meaning or not?

That could, I think that could be, yes. Yeah. I don't, I don't want to be too suggestive, so I'm not going to put any words into your mouth and it's a lot, it's open for interpretation a lot.

Okay. Yeah. But I think that could be, yeah. Because, I mean, something can have meaning, but it means something bad to you.

That could be. Yeah. Yeah.

The political recording of that, our current, um, vice, not vice president, but it, uh, prime minister. Yeah. Uh, but, um, yeah, uh, I think, should I, should I answer what makes it meaningful to me?

Yes.

Um, I guess, I guess then the words need to have some meaning to me, like more than the tone of, more than the tone of voice and, um, intonation or like even the,

more the information they carry, uh, in terms of if that information is touching me or not. Yes. So, if something can already be personal to you, if it sounds good, so how they speak and it can actually only be really meaningful about if it's about what they speak about. Yeah.

Yes. Okay. And so how does that kind of correlate to your understanding of personal recordings and generic recordings? Do you think there's a correlation there with meaningfulness?

Oh, yes. Like some color, color, uh, some correlation for sure. Uh, like, um, I'm guessing that if it's meaningful, uh, it's gonna be more personal in like immediately. Um, but it, it doesn't need to be very pers, uh, doesn't need to be very meaningful if it's personal, something like that. Yes.

Yeah. I understand what you mean. Yeah. And, um, can you think of a situation or maybe multiple situations, um, in which you would think one specific voice recording would be more meaningful in one situation and less meaningful in another? So for example, uh, being alone at home or being with friends or feeling homesick or not, those would be examples of different situations.

Mm-hmm. Mm-hmm. And one, uh, having different influence on you kind of.

Yeah. So if you have one specific voice recording, uh, that it would be different in meaningfulness in two different situations.

Uh, yes. Yeah. Yeah. Yeah. I think, yeah, definitely. I think it depends on the state you are in. How are you feeling right now? And what are you doing? And I feel like also if you're busy or not, it might have an impact.

Yeah. All right. Um, so I'm going to go back to the questionnaire now and I'm going to let you hear the same five voice recordings. And then you can select how meaningful or not meaningful they feel to you. So it's just going to be the same five statements, but then, um, ranging from not meaningful at all to very meaningful.

Okay.

All right. So just let me know when you're ready.

Okay, I'm ready.

[Voice recording audio: recording 1]

[Voice recording audio: recording 2]

[Voice recording audio: recording 5]

[Voice recording audio: recording 12]

[Voice recording audio: recording 19]

Alright. So, going back to the interview again. And now based on the same recordings, what do you think made them more or less meaningful?

Yeah, I guess, like I was also thinking about it that I also, I don't know if I told you, I lived in France. But I don't know French. So, like if it has any meaning to me, it's like a language that I have been listening to for one year without understanding it. So, like something like that. So, it carries maybe just like a very slight meaning to me. But that's, I think, just external bias that has nothing to do with the interview. Or like maybe it's a little bit towards the fact that many places can be home. But it's like barely meaningful. So, that's the scale. So, on the other things that are in my language, I think again, the weather was meaningful somewhat. Because also the guy sounds like cheerful and nice. And then the historical speech was very meaningful, but very negatively meaningful to me. So, it can have an impact on me, but not because I'm very happy about the things he's saying. And then the third one was kind of somewhat meaningful to me because, okay, she's talking about a holiday, but she's also talking in it still in a very neutral voice. Like it's something that you would hear on the TV. Yeah.

Yeah. Okay. And so, finally, I want to go into the actual supportiveness for coping with homesickness. And then I mean, whether you feel like a voice recording actually would alleviate your feeling of homesickness and to what extent, or maybe worsen your homesickness.

Uh-huh. Uh-huh.

So, once again, if you think about voice recordings in general, what do you think might impact that alleviation of homesickness or worsening of homesickness?

Um, let me just see, what can impact? Uh, I think, I think it's mostly the person who is speaking, to be honest. Um, for that one. Or, okay, yeah. Or the story, yeah. If the story they're telling, whatever, it's very relatable to me. Yes. Yeah. So, yeah.

Yes. And can you think of a situation in which one specific voice recording would feel more supportive for homesickness than in another situation?

Um, more supportive gives you hope versus gives you, I don't know, um, sadness or whatever. Uh, but I think, in general, I'm not sure how much the voice recordings can help. I think they might make it worse. Or, like, that's my first, uh, inclination. Uh, but, uh, yeah. If they're positive, maybe, I don't know, maybe it is fine.

Yeah. Okay, so let's go back to the questionnaire for the final time. I'm gonna let you hear the same recordings again.

Okay.

And you can tell me, um, how supportive they are or how not supportive they are.

Okay.

And then afterwards, you can, uh, submit the questionnaire, then it's done.

Yeah. Okay.

[Voice recording audio: recording 1]

[Voice recording audio: recording 2]

[Voice recording audio: recording 5]

[Voice recording audio: recording 12]

[Voice recording audio: recording 19]

All right. So you can submit it now. And then kind of the same question again. What do you think of the characteristics and the situations, the context, and what made it more or less supportive for you?

Okay. Yeah. I think talking about politics in Bulgaria is not supportive at all.

Yes.

Talking about the weather in a cheerful voice in your language can be supportive somewhat helping you if you feel homesick and, I don't know, you're not talking Bulgarian to anyone around you. So I guess here is more like you could feel close through the words, but not very, like, the information is not as important in this. Like, it would be maybe similar to hearing a song, like, that you like or somehow in your language, in the native language. The other thing is maybe, like, I was wondering if the other language can help me feel less homesick. I think, like, not really, I mean, it's neutral, I think. Yeah. But maybe it could, depending, depending on your feelings towards the language or whatever, I think. So, because sometimes I feel like for homesickness, you, if you want to get out of it, it sometimes is not helpful to immerse yourself even more in what's making your home sick. So, depends on how you want to deal with that. Because, like, avoiding it is also probably not going to help that much, but...

Yeah, exactly. And I think in the Bulgarian, you would say, if I'm correct, you would say the first recording, so about the weather would be then the most supportive for you?

Supportive, yeah. Yeah.

And do you think that's then mainly a bit about the topic? So maybe the formality of it?

It's not the topic, it's the... So, I guess there is, like, a fourth hidden... Like, not a fourth hidden scale, but like, something like about the politician talking about a party that I do not support. And the lady talking in a very, how do you say, like... Neutral, I'm not, like, about patriotic things. Like, I don't necessarily am sad or sick about the political situation of Bulgaria. Like, even, like, the opposite. Like, if it was different, maybe I would have been there instead. But, um, it's like, uh... Yeah, I don't know. Like, if it was an activist talking about some topic that... Bulgarian activist or whatever, talking about some topic that I support, and I'm pro... Yeah. Um, maybe it would be different, but this does not support me in my... Homesickness alleviation or whatever you did the question on. Yeah.

And finally, I would like you to imagine a voice recording of someone just very close to you. So maybe a family member, a good friend. Um, and they're speaking to you directly about something personal. And how meaningful do you think that would be? And how supportive for coping with homesickness?

Yeah, I think it would be very meaningful and... Um... Not supportive at all or very supportive depending on what they're saying.

Yes. And do you think, uh, because it depends on what they're saying, do you think that the distance between you and the person is also a big, uh, part?

Yeah. Um, sorry, I was imagining people who are, uh, Bulgarian people who do not live in Bulgaria sending me this, but, uh, yes, it would matter, I think. Um, or like it would matter where they are or like what's their situation is, uh, like what their base, uh, baseline is. Yeah.

Yeah. All right. Um, well, that was already basically it. Is there anything we haven't covered that you still want to say?

Um... No, it would be interesting to read the paper once you're... it's written.

Yes. It'll be done in, uh, two weeks. Um, and just a final question, if you're willing to share or if you can even, um, imagine anything. Um, if you could choose one voice recording or one type of voice recording that would actually be very effective for supportiveness, uh, for coping with homesickness. What do you think it would be according to you?

Oh, that's, that's a very hard question. I don't know. Um, I think, um, the example of, uh, somebody who is close to me, um, but also, so, so, okay. So somebody who has been feeling also homesick and is not in their country, um, talking like, um, um, Um, I

don't know, sharing something in our shared native language. Um, but also, it may, it may be very relatable and being understood in, in terms of like, um, like in terms of the concept of home is wherever your closest people are, or like every time you're talking to them, you know, you can feel at home. Um, so I think in that sense, it kind of alleviates homesickness to the point where it's, um, just for that moment, talking to them or hearing that voice note, you might not, or like feel less homesick, but that doesn't necessarily mean that it would be, uh, long, uh, like that it would help you long term for, or like not long term, but like probably it would help you for like the day or whatever. That doesn't mean that it's gonna really alleviate anything long term.

Yes. Okay. Um, well, thanks so I'm just going to turn off the recording.